

KF29 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

We are now beginning the third quarter of the KF training cycle, and you may wish to return a gift to Karis Fellowships that represents your gratitude for what you have gained. If you have received, it is vital that you give, for it is a principle of circulation that receiving without giving will stagnate your life. If you do not circulate, you will die. Visit **Give a Gift** on the website, or you can donate financially through PayPal to finance@karisfellowships.com. Any gift at all keeps you circulating.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

KF Confession 7 opens the door to God’s kingdom. We give a great gift to God and to our community by walking through this door.

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

The practice of meditation and mindfulness trains our minds and emotions to step back from reacting to life’s events. We practice mindfulness to break the grip of our compelling need to be right, to be comfortable, to restore our pride, and to flee from self-hate. When we commit to live in reality, we are choosing to courageously face the truth of who we are today and the truth about others. We observe ourselves and our outcomes with compassion, and we calm ourselves as we would calm a distressed child. In the calm we find a creative, positive place within, where we can connect to God and co-labor with Him to produce glorious, oriented outcomes.

This month we are practicing **Calming Breath**. Nancy likes to use this method when she needs to calm down or when lying down before sleep. **Calming Breath** is very effective for quieting a distressed body and mind. During this exercise, you will use sound to help your body release tension. Make sure that you are on mute while we practice together.

Calming Breath

1. Prepare

Assume a meditation posture. You may wish to lie down. Settle into this experience and experiment. *(Pause)* Begin with a silent prayer for peace within yourself and in your life. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Scan for tension

As you inhale, explore your body for tension. You might start with your feet and ankles. On the exhale, try to release any tension in that area. Then, as you continue to breathe, move your attention to other areas. Remember to explore your face. Our faces often speak louder than our words, so cultivate the habit of noticing what your face is doing. Relax, let go, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. Use sound

When you feel somewhat connected to your body, use the word *CALM* as a centering word. Prolong the “ahm” sound while you softly voice the word, as if you were releasing a sigh. Here is an example. *(Give one breath as an example)* Feel your body let go and relax. You might exhale using sound for one breath and then rest quietly during the next breath, or you might scan your body again and release any tension with the sound. Continue at your own pace for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

4. Use breath

When you feel ready, let go of saying the word out loud. Allow the word to flow in your mind with your breath, or whisper the word *CALM* like this. *(Demonstrate one example)* Continue for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, release the word altogether. Deeply breathe and occasionally sigh with long exhaling breaths. Continue to release any tension in your body and mind. If an issue continues to intrude, try using the **UFO Hold**. Place the palm of one hand on your forehead and the palm of your other hand on the back of your neck. Gently move your head around as you breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

5. Rest

Breathe while you rest in the stillness with a quiet mind. If you notice your mind wandering, use the word *CALM* to draw it back into stillness. Stillness is a place of rest in your mind where there are no images, no words, and no thoughts—a very attentive but still space where you simply wait. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Gently stretch, open your eyes, and re-engage with the meeting. **Calming Breath** trains your mind and body to relax on command. It is out of the calm that we find our path to orientation. Take time throughout the day to find that calm space and give God a chance to guide you.

Our hymn for this meditation is *Spirit of God, Descend upon my Heart* by George Croly, an Irish clergyman who achieved his mission through creatively dealing with limitations.

Spirit of God, descend upon my heart.
Wean it from earth; through all its pulses move.
Stoop to my weakness, mighty as Thou art,
And let me love Thee as I ought to love.¹

Take a deep breath.

As our language degrades, much of its wealth of meaning is lost. In the past, the English language had two forms of address, the formal *you* and the intimate *thou*. So, when you hear the words *thou* or *thee* in a hymn or poem, you know that it is referring to an intimate relationship, as in a family or between lovers.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let’s look at the worksheet titled **Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself**. Hopefully, you have downloaded this worksheet from the **Toolbox** page of the KF website and printed it out. You can also find this worksheet under the **Meeting Guides and Teachings** for KF29.

All suffering is an invitation to develop the muscles of courage and endurance, but only strategic suffering builds those muscles in our soul. Last week we were reminded that, as the children of God, suffering is part of our birthing process. At the beginning of any new challenge, we will suffer. This suffering helps to crack the hard shell of pride so that we are free to lay aside old misoriented habits and patterns and learn healthier ways to live. We are then able to step into the next challenge on our road to the glory of God with more confidence and more joy. This process is repeated throughout our ever-developing life.

We are no longer the victims of our suffering. We are now explorers of the opportunities that God offers to teach us how to successfully engage in the reality of *what is*. The worksheet for this lesson will help you explore the potential of your suffering. Let’s look at it together.

Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself

THE STORY

The questions in this first section help you focus your energy around the issues linked to your suffering. Don’t worry if you can’t figure it all out. Keep in mind that your humble intention to reorient yourself invites God to be an ally in your healing process. If you get stuck on any step, just move on to the next one.

1. Identify the source of your suffering

First, look at your story. Write down whatever or whoever seems to be the cause of your suffering.

2. Recognize your feelings

Nancy has given you a list of feelings on this worksheet, but you can also glean from the lists on other worksheets or come up with your own words to describe your feelings. If you can define what you are feeling, the integration and healing process at the end of the worksheet will be more effective.

3. Scan your body

Think about the apparent cause of your suffering and notice how your body is reacting.

4. Spot the pattern

Have you experienced this type of suffering before? Just answer yes or no.

5. Anniversary trauma

Sometimes our present suffering is weighted with unprocessed trauma from past experiences. If we can identify that past suffering, we might be able to understand the intensity of our present feelings.

This understanding can help us calm our feelings and renew our courage to keep working toward health.

PRIDE

1. Write down how you, in your infinite wisdom, think the situation *should* or *shouldn't* be

This is just a plain statement of fact. For example, if you are suffering at work, you could write statements like these: "I shouldn't have to do this job. I should enjoy my job. I should have a different boss or co-worker. People shouldn't get in my way."

2. Recognize the judgment

Next, you will identify the judgment. In other words, what have you judged to be bad about your situation? You might judge that others are bad, that your circumstances are bad, or that you are bad and ungrateful. Remember that it is possible to judge seemingly good things as bad.

3. Categorize your story

This step helps you identify the types of stories that you tell to explain your fear and justify your suffering. Recognizing your story in this list can sometimes be rather humbling, but humility is what we want to learn.

THE MIRROR

This section gives you an opportunity to look at yourself. These are simple yes or no questions. Perhaps you now understand that simple choices can have astonishing results. Just answer yes or no.

WISDOM FROM ABOVE

Your responses to your suffering reveal the source of your wisdom. In this section, Nancy refers to a passage from James to help you identify your source. If you do not see in your life the qualities that come from the *Wisdom from Above*, your thoughts and choices need to be reoriented. However, if you do recognize characteristics of the *Wisdom from Above*, be sure to give yourself credit. The **Expanded Version** of this lesson offers a more detailed explanation of these characteristics.

JOY

Do you remember learning from James that you can guide yourself into joy? God designed you to be joyful, even in the midst of your suffering, but you need training. When you experience suffering of any kind, you have an opportunity to train.

ACTION

You can now use KF integration tools to process what you have just learned in the worksheet and align yourself with *Wisdom from Above*.

Let's review our quote from last week.

Research has shown that repeated action, learning, and memory can actually change the nervous system physically, altering both synaptic strength and connections. Such changes

may be brought about by cultivated change in emotion and action; they will, in turn, change subsequent experience.²

We are cultivating these changes by practicing the tools of Karis Fellowships.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Spirit of truth, reveal the real source of my suffering. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Oh, blessed moment! After six months of KF training, we are now ready to embrace KF Confession 7:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Our inner conflicts and compelling needs force us into the wisdom, or cleverness, of taking cheap, habitual shortcuts that make us a target for demonic infiltration. In order to create outcomes of orientation, we must regularly think and act in ways that will promote calm and peace in our lives. Through prayer and meditation, mindfulness training, circulation, and the use of our KF tools, we are sowing seeds of oriented choices, which over time will produce a harvest of oriented outcomes. We will then have more and more access to the wisdom from above. The effort we make to plant these seeds is the cause that produces the glorious effect of a peaceful and fulfilled life—a life that flows out of a mature and fully equipped True Self.

We really do need to respect the reality of cause and effect. Whatever we do, whether oriented or misoriented, we plant seeds. Seeds determine the harvest, and a quality harvest begins with quality seed. The Bible tells us how to plant quality seed—seeds of orientation—which will produce the abundant harvest of an ever-developing, glorious life.

A well-known passage about cause and effect is found in chapter 6 of Paul’s letter to the Galatians. This is Nancy’s paraphrase of **Galatians 6:7–10**.

⁷Do not be influenced to wander and misorient. God is not to be outwitted or sneered at. This is how it works: whatever a person sows, that will they also reap. ⁸For the one who sows into the Idol Self (or the flesh), out of the Idol Self will reap deterioration and ruin; but the one who sows into the True Self (or the spirit), out of the True Self will reap an ever-developing life. ⁹Since this is so, do not be negligent in doing what is virtuous and beautiful. If we do not relax our effort, we will reap at the proper time and in due season. ¹⁰Therefore, when any opportunity presents itself to you, perform what is of benefit to all, but especially to the trustworthy community.

Take a deep breath.

Nancy writes about her own ignorance of cause and effect:

When I was a young adult, I didn't understand the principle of cause and effect. I thought that a bag of cookies was an adequate lunch, that time was something I could manipulate to accommodate my compulsive needs, and that my performance was unaffected by fatigue or lack of sleep. I thought that God controlled everything, so I allowed myself to be controlled by everything. I was egocentrically sowing into the Idol Self and expected the Harvest of the Spirit in return. I assumed that everyone, including God, would accommodate me.

In this passage from Galatians we can see that God supports the cause and effect process, but in our misorientation we don't want to believe that. We prefer to believe that if we put energy and resources into our cravings, judgments, and pride, we can still hope to get satisfying outcomes. Our pride system wastes an enormous amount of energy making judgments that generate self-hate, and then we expend more energy chasing perfection in a frantic attempt to maintain our pride and protect ourselves from a further onslaught of self-hate. We can choose to sow either judgment or love, and the reality is that we will reap whatever we sow, whether in our work, our relationships, our own health and development, or in our play. In KF, we are learning to sow our energy and resources into the ways of eternity, and as a result, our True Self is reaping eternal life from the Spirit of God. Eternal life constitutes all the glorious qualities of growth and orientation that can be experienced in this life and beyond. Even when we don't feel like it, we can choose life;³ we can courageously do productive, orienting things and grow into our potential as spiritual creatures living in this material world.

Let's turn to our beloved letter from James. This is Nancy's translation of **James 5:7–9**.

⁷Therefore, be long-tempered my siblings, until the Lord presents Himself. Consider this: the farmer, being long-tempered, waits for the valuable and prized fruit of the earth until he receives the early and afternoon showers. ⁸You also, be long-tempered. Resolve to turn your hearts around because the presence of the Lord approaches. ⁹Siblings, do not groan in judgment against others or you yourself risk being judged. Look! The real Judge is standing at the door!

Take a deep breath.

You might think of the principle of cause and effect in this way: *"My life is what it is because. . ."* Be your own cause. (Repeat) You are the cause that generated the outcomes you have. You are a powerful creature, and your power can be directed toward generating different outcomes. Outcomes are not created by magic or luck; you create them. Begin generating new outcomes by first becoming the cause of your own orientation, and then see what happens. Take care of your business. Your business is to sow good seed, do good work, speak good thoughts, give good gifts, and then wait. Allow others time to take care of their business; and, especially, with humility allow God time to take care of His.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Great Sower of the logos, show me where to sow good seeds that will reap an abundant harvest.
(Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and you might wish to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of your life, or a person, into which you can sow oriented seed. (Repeat)* That person could be yourself. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider an area where you might sow some oriented seed*, breathe and recognize your feelings or the absence of feelings. Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. As you *consider an area where you might sow some oriented seed*, observe and explore your experience without judgment. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing right now as you *consider sowing oriented seed into this area of your life or into another’s life*. Observe those sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of sowing oriented seed*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider sowing this oriented seed? What might be possible? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore the causes of your life.
- Welcome the gentle Holy Counselor, who can show you where to sow.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁴

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for control and getting my own way.

- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for respect and affection.
- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for survival and comfort.
- While sowing seeds of orientation, I let go of the longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Remind us that we are the cause of the quality of our own lives. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to become more effective and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

Pray for the members of Karis Fellowships, that God would help us plant seeds of time, talent, and finances to make possible a harvest of orientation in this world.

¹ *Spirit of God Descend Upon My Heart* by George Croly (1780–1860); www.youtube.com/watch?v=ymKxTkrRNBA.

² Maggie Macnab, *Decoding Design: Understanding and Using Symbols in Visual Communication* (How Books, 2008), 174.

³ Deut. 30:19.

⁴ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.